

Kiya Grivalsky

Edward Karshner

Creative Writing

December 12, 2024

Self- Reflection:

This semester has allowed me to take a step back and kind fall into the genre that I not only enjoy watching in movies and entertainment but I have also discovered that I low key enjoy writing it as well. I always knew that I had a creative story mind but I never thought that I could turn the thoughts in my head into words on a page. I have always told my story through pictures instead of words. So this semester has opened my eyes to a new way to express my creativity and express it with others.

In terms of defining my process, it all starts out with what I like to call “word vomit on a page”. In another words nothing makes sense, there are no transitions, it is just simply words on a page. This gives me an idea what I want in my story and what direction that I want it to go in. Then from there I will start with the intro and come up with a solid first paragraph, or one that I can at least tolerate for the time being. Then I will move to my main paragraphs, adding in details, and transitions. I will then go in and polish everything, adding transitions in between paragraphs making sure everything flows together. Finally I will write the conclusion.

I often tend to write very early in the mornings (5am) when work is slow or the exact opposite, late at night when I have off of work the next day. One thing that I have noticed I tend to come up with my best story ideas when I am either not fully awake or I am really tired. Then tend to

just be a random thought (almost as if a lightbulb lit or a flashlight in my head). Most of the time I wasn't even trying to think of an idea.

I wouldn't really say that there is anything in particular that I need to do better. There is always more for improvements. However, I feel that my writing process works for me, and there is not much more that I can do for than that.

For the most part I feel confident in the pieces that I wrote this semester. Although I like my CNF piece and I think I did a decent job on it, I love my fiction piece and think that it has so much potential. I went way out of my comfort zone on this piece and chose to write in a genre that I always watch in movies but never considered to write in, and I truly believed that it paid off. Overall I really enjoyed writing both of these pieces and I am proud of the work that I have done this semester.

Author Bio:

Kiya Grivalsky is a college student and aspiring author who has devoted a significant portion of her artistic life to using graphic design and drawings to tell stories. She has always found comfort in using pictures to convey her ideas, feelings, and stories because she is a visual artist at heart. Her artistic journey, however, took a significant turn this semester when she realized the power of words and that she could use written language to weave stories in addition to visual storytelling. She can now explore both traditional writing and visual storytelling from a new angle thanks to her newly discovered ability to combine her two hobbies.

As a child, Kiya was fascinated with films and other visual media, especially those in the horror genre], which sparked her creativity and influenced her early urge to write stories. She had always wanted to write stories in these genres, but she did not know she could write in them until recently. Kiya jumped into writing fiction this semester after learning new writing strategies in her creative writing class. She was amazed by how well her visual storytelling abilities fit her writing style. What began as an easy word experiment has developed into an effective combination of writing and art.

Kiya is currently working on further developing her latest fiction piece that combines her love of visual art with her recently discovered passion for written storytelling as she continues to broaden her creative horizons. She likes to push the limits of how various artistic mediums can collaborate to produce intriguing narratives, and her work frequently examines themes of mystery, adventure, and horror.

Kiya likes to play basketball, or go out with friends when she isn't working on her writing or making graphics. As she develops as an artist and storyteller, she can't wait to try new things with writing and drawing

Cover Letter:

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Edward Karshner
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Dear Prof.,

I'm writing to offer two pieces that highlight my development as a artist and writer for consideration. My creative journey as a college student has been significantly influenced by my special passion for visual media and graphic storytelling. I never thought I would be able to blend written words with my artistic expression until recently. But after realizing the power of writing as a medium in and of itself this semester, I've been observing in my work how written narrative and visual art intersect. I hope these pieces provide some insight into this exciting development.

"The Humming Bird and Red Robin Tale," describes my relationship with the red robins and hummingbirds that showed up in my yard soon after Gram, the woman who was like a grandmother to me, passed away. I felt a sense of wonder and a bittersweet sense of closure when I saw these birds, especially the hummingbirds flying between the flowers. They seemed

to me like a kind of sign, a gentle reminder that even in the face of loss, life goes on in its own way. The story examines how these birds came to represent the strength and affection that Gram had always possessed. I describe how the birds' presence assisted me in finding peace and processing my grief using vivid, detailed language. What started out as a narrative about my own loss evolved into a more thorough overview of the seasonal nature of life and the delicate beauty of nature. I've always used visual art to convey my feelings, so this was my first attempt at using words to convey something so personal.

The second piece, "*The Mysterious Woods*," takes a different approach, focusing on the creepy mystery of the woods down by the river. This story, however, marks my first foray into the Folk-horror genre—a genre I've long adored in film but never thought I could write in. The piece explores the act of horror and adventure, using genre conventions to delve into a dark and gory mystery of the unknown. I've always been drawn to the escapism and the moral complexities that the genre offers, and I was thrilled to discover I could create these worlds through words as well as through visual art. This piece is my attempt to explore the genre's possibilities and my place within it.

My writing falls somewhere between fiction, magical realism, horror, and graphic storytelling. Similar to writers like Isabel Allende, and J. K. Rowling, my work examines the boundary between the real and the fantastic, but it also adds a visual component that is specific to my artistic experience. Drawing from my experience in graphic design, I use my eye for vivid imagery and emotional power to tell stories that are both written and seen, in contrast to many writers in these genres who only concentrate on narrative.

Despite the fact that my writing career is still in its early stages, I have written several short stories. I can't wait to keep honing my voice and broadening my creative horizons. I'm

especially interested in seeing how words and images can work together to create stories that are more complex and dynamic.

Sincerely,

Kiya Grivalsky

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Edward Karshner

Creative Writing

September 12, 2024

The Humming Bird and Red Robin Tale

It was early fall, the leaves were being to fall from the trees and the wind whirled with delight. The days were getting shorter and the nights were getting colder though everything still seemed rather peaceful and clam. Despite it all, I couldn't seem to avoid the roaring feelings of grief and memory.

I took a walk by the side of the fence to ponder on my grief of the loss over the closet thing that I have ever had to a grandma. I then continued to walk down the street past a rather familiar sight. There, suddenly, was a quick flicker of a light that zoomed past my eye. What could that be, I wondered with great delight. I found myself in-front of very familiar stomping grounds, Grams' old house. As I head up the steps to get a closer look, I noticed a small blur of green hovering around a feeder hanging from a tree. "No that can't be, I said to the." There is a humming bird dancing in the tree. I leaned closer to the tree to get a better look, struggling to catch my breath as I watched this gleam of light fly back and forth. I could watch this all day and not even care, cause it's memory lays forever to share.

My Gram always loved Humming Birds, and Red Robins. No matter where you look in Grams house you were about bound to find a Red Robin or a Humming bird. Her whole home had an elegant/earthy feel with a theme of the two birds. Everyday no matter the hour, Gram would fill up and put out the humming bird feeders and we would watch them for hours. She always told me that they “Were little miracles”, and I never understood why. Yes, they were fun to watch and always a rather unique and beautiful sight. I just never understood what she meant by that ,but now as I sit here and am looking at these beautiful birds, I think I get it now. Gram, I think I get it now! I know what she has been trying to tell me all these years. This tiny little bird was filling with so much energy and was drawing me to it, almost as if it was trying to tell me something.

A few weeks went by and I once again am sitting on my porch playing with my dog, and look at my fence and can't help to notice something in the tree. I was red and beautiful, it good out like a green thumb (but a red one). I couldn't believe it I once again see a Red Robin. Memories of Gram flowed through the sunlight on my skin. She was my role model, my support, the Grandma figure I never had, and most importantly had greatly impacted my life. Her words guided through storms and her kindness filled rooms with warmth. When she passed away, I felt as if a part of me was missing, and that's a whole that will never be patched.

I would spend with her as soon as school was over. We would have cookies for lunch and play card games till we couldn't no more. We would search for red robins nest in trees and humming birds dancing with glee. “They're messengers”, she said with great

degree. "They bring us good luck and great joy". We would sit there together, whispering our luck as if they work like a toy. The birds couldn't understand us, but it was our secret that they could. We would be out there for hours until the moonlight towers the sky.

Now that spring is approaching, and the birds are blooming. I began to notice red robins appearing again. They landed on my fence over and over, for a year went by and I see them more all over. They even began to come rather closer. One day while I was sitting on the porch, I left a few crumbs wondering if they would come right over. A red robin landed a few feet away, there is not too much more that I can say. It was a beautiful sight that I once again to to see before it was even May.

In that moment, I felt a sense of warmth in my heart, the sense that life continued despite it all. My mom always said "Those that love us will show signs through nature that speaks to them." It's there way of telling us that they are there, without us being able to physically see them.

As school began to conclude and my free time began to up root. I found my self outside more often, in search for red robins. Trying to find my inner Gram in the piece and quiet. In the these moments ,my mind began to feel at ease, as I dreamed of Grams' laughter and cheer. Her memories will live in both my mind and heart forever. I never meet any of my Grandmas, so having Gram by my side whenever I needed her meant more than ever.

As summer ended... I took a stroll down the street, passing Gram's old house with great belief. As I took one more step, I noticed something rather unusual: there was a humming bird hovering in front of me, as if it was studying me. Although it darted away right away, it then returned moments later. It almost felt as if the bird wanted me to join him. I closed my eyes, and tried to in vision gram there with me embracing this beautiful bird. My heart os complete and filled with less sorrow.

From that day on, I often thought about all what Gram has taught me, to find light in even the darkest of times. It was if these birds were encouraging me to keep moving forward, and to honor and cherish Grams' legacy. A Humming bird symbolizes intelligence, beauty, devotion, love and Good luck (all of which Gram had). These birds also not on remind me of Grams love and devotion to those around her but it also makes me think of the good that she wants to bring upon me despite her physically not being present. These birds, with their gentle presence and melodious songs, also serve as a comforting reminder of Grams' enduring love and the positive influence she continues to have on my life. And so, each time I have an encounter with these birds, it serves as my reminder that love truly never leaves.

Kiya Grivalsky

Edward Karshner

Fiction

October 22, 2024

The Mysterious Woods:

With its streets lined with crooked houses that appeared to lean toward one another as if sharing secrets, Maplewood was a town cloaked in creepy occurrences. With a few flickering spotlights creating spooky shadows on the crumbling pavement, the once lively town square now sat dead and silent. Maplewood was surrounded by the notorious Evil Woods, a shadowy grove that sucked up light and sound, its twisted trees bending upward like skeletal fingers. Every now and then, a howling howl would appear through the night, reminding the locals of the horror that lurked just beyond their threshold, and the never ending fog would sweep in from the forest, leaving the town in a large embrace.

The early morning mist whispered through the wind, breaking the silence among the trees. Everything seemed calm and quiet. In the silence awoke a call, a resident reported hearing someone call for help near by. The dispatcher listened carefully as the caller described the sound: frantic, desperate, and undeniably human.

Officer Emily Board was the first to respond to the scene. She stepped into the shadows of the trees, she could feel the darkness and the cold air breathing down her neck. Holding her

flashlight, with fear in her eyes she calls out, “Hello, Is anyone there? Just then she hears nothing, it like it went away.

After searching the area for several hours she decided to call it a night and headed back to her cruiser. Officer Emily Board was looking down by the river and she noticed something. Emily saw a modest house standing in a short distance on the other side of the woods just slightly beyond the river. It looked rather rough and unattended from the outside, the paint was peeling and the grass was very overgrown. A faint bark echoed within sending a cool chill down Emily’s back.

Emily approached the house, as a rather scruffy man was approaching her. The man asked “Can I help you”? The officer explained “We have received a call about someone screaming for help, Did you hear anything”? The man shook his head and frowned. “No, but I have been looking for my dog, Help. He’s been missing since late last night.”

“Help” repeated Emily, your dog’s name is Help”? Confusion ran through her mind. “Yeah, odd name, I know” said the man. I found him left down by the river when he was just a small puppy, his previous owner must have abandoned him. I thought his name would fit. He Is known to wonder but he always come back. However, this time he has just been gone way too long and I am worried about him. The man goes on to say how he has heard some rather unusual noises coming from the woods, he’s never heard these type of noises before. The man the goes on to

describe these noises as, “dying animals”. The man claims that it’s as if something or someone is in the woods drawing these animals to them and killing them. The man says “It’s almost as if anything that goes in never comes out”.

Emily was trying to piece it together with what little she knew. She had a sense she was on the right track, but there are still too many unknowns. However, the sun began to rise and Emily decided it was time to give the man a rest. Emily left him with her contact information just in case he happens to think of any more helpful information or run into another issue. Emily promised to keep an eye out for Help, but as the day slipped by, the world grew thicker with tension. The residents of Maplewood began to get on edge, as the news about what was going on began to spread more and more.

Later that next day, the old man ventured into the woods, calling his dog’s name until his voice cracked. His heart racing each time that his echo spit back at him. He pondered, “what could have happened to him”, “Where could he be,” “Is okay” ?The man had no answer to any of these questions. All he knew was strange things were happening and they were beyond his control. Things that he couldn’t even put into words to explain to other’s what he was hearing or experiencing.

Days turned into weeks, and the initial fear of Help’s disappearance transformed into a sense of dread. Strange occurrences began to infect the town: shadows grew between trees, items went

missing from homes, and many were starting to feel a sense of being watched.. The man's once-cozy home became a sense of anxiety, his sleep disrupted by the feeling of a presence wondering just out of sight. Are residents of the town of Maplewood safe in their own homes? Now residents can't be so sure with everything that has been going on around them.,.

One night, as the man stared out of his window, he spotted a flickering light deep within the woods. Curiosity rose, he grabbed a flashlight and stepped outside. The glow pulsed in some sort of rhythm, almost as if it was drawing him in. As he ventured deeper, he felt a deeper pull, as if the woods themselves were guiding him. Suddenly, he stumbled upon something, where the light revealed a circle of stones, ancient and worn. In the center sat a pile of dog collars—some frayed and beat up, others in perfect condition. Each collar bore a name, a haunting collection of lost companions. At that moment, the man understood: this was not just about Help. The woods held something darker, a form of violence that thrived on fear and loss.

The townspeople began to whisper about the man whose dog was lost, and about the strange happenings that had fallen upon Maplewood since Help vanished. One missing dog sparked this missing of several others and not just dogs but belongings and people too.

Months passed, and one stormy night, the man stood on his porch, sad and overwhelmed. He called out into the darkness, "Help! Where are you?" Then, just as the wind howled, a familiar bark pierced the air. The man's heart raced, a flicker of hope within him. He sprinted into the woods, following the sound as it danced around him, leading him deeper than ever before. But the closer he got, the fainter the barking became, until it vanished altogether.

In that moment, the man realized that Help was gone. And as he stood alone beneath the twisted branches, a chilling thought settled over him: sometimes, the help we seek is the most elusive of all. Just a few moments later the man heard a rather familiar bark. "It can't be", he said. He didn't hesitate for a second he ran into the woods. Screaming "Help, Help, Is that you"? His heart one again trembled with both hope and fear. His steps felt heavier with each step he took as the shadows became deeper and deeper, the air great colder and colder. The air was filled with a very weird yet unfamiliar scent, making his stomach churn.

Just as the man was getting ready to head back, he saw a slight glimpse of movement through the tangled branches. A small glimpse of fur, black and brown rustled in the trees. With his adrenaline running high, he started running towards it. When he approached a rather thick truck, his breath got lost in his throat.

There stood Help, but nowhere near how he remembered him. He had lost the playful, devoted dog he had cherished. It had been replaced by a warped, hideous version, its eyes gleaming with an unnatural light. Its once-familiar bark had changed into a deep, unnatural growl that echoed with an unearthly quality as it rumbled from its throat.

With disbelief beginning to seep into his heart, he whispered, "Help?" The creature paused, tilting its head as though it was thinking about him. The ancient spark briefly glowed in those bright eyes before fading and giving way to unknown hunger.

The man stepped back, a chilly, confused look forming on his forehead. "How did they harm you?" He struggled to balance his desperate need to save his friend with his instinct to run.

He raised his arms as the creature lunged forward, sensing the raw power roaring from its new and improved form. But as if it recognized the scent of its former life, it stopped short of him, nostrils flaring, rather than attacking.

The man's mind exploded with recognition. "Help... You're in there, I know that. Fight it! Battle whatever has taken you. He felt the weight of their relationship, the years they had spent together, every adventure they had taken, and every quiet moment they had spent together.

The creature paused, the light in its eyes fluttering, fighting between the remains of his beloved dog and the demon's grip. He briefly believed he saw the spirit of Help straining to free itself, and he grabbed that ray of hope.

"Do you recall our walks? The creek? The manner in which you once chased the squirrels? Emotion was raw in his voice. "You're stronger than this! Return to me!

It snarled, loudly as though in a storm, and its increased snarls echoed throughout the forest. With his heart racing, the man moved closer, determined to get to the dog he had known. "Please, Help! I beg you!

The creature let out one last, frantic howl before collapsing to the ground, its body writhing as though it were caught in a struggle for control. The light in its eyes gradually faded, and for a moment the warmth that had been there before reappeared.

Then the change came back in a flash, and Help lay again, panting, exhausted but whole, his tail thudding freely on the forest floor. The man knelt next to him, holding the dog's head in his hands while tears ran down his cheeks.

He whispered, "I thought I lost you." However, even now the woods felt alive, dark, and observing.

He pulled Help to his feet and said, "Let's get out of here." But he knew in his heart that the forest had influenced him. It was still out there.

The man experienced a shock of confusion as soon as he felt the warmth of Help against him. The soft creak of his porch swing took the place of the familiar rustle of leaves. The woods abruptly vanished around him as he blinked, confused.

He had returned to his porch, where the sun was shining through the trees and creating amusing shadows on the wood floor. At his feet, Help was snoring quietly, completely oblivious to the nightmare that had just played out in his owner's head. It dawned on him suddenly that it had all been a dream. "None of this had been real, no that can't be".

His heart pounded, but it was a familiar throb of relief rather than fear. He looked at Help, comforted by his furry chest's steady rise and fall. "Just a dream," he whispered, but the experience still weighed heavily on him, echoing in his mind like a ghost.

But a chill went down his spine even as he made an effort to get rid of the last of the fear. The dream's details—the growl, the darkness, and the struggle for Help's spirit—were too real. Was it a warning, or just a trick of his imagination?

Reaching down, he scratched behind Help's ears. He steadied his voice as the warmth of reality surrounded him and said, "You're still here, buddy." He couldn't get rid of the feeling that something was waiting there, just out of sight, though, because the woods loomed just beyond the porch, a maze of whispers and shadows.

With the need for fresh air pulling at him, he decided it might be time for a walk. Help raised his head, tail wagging as though to say, "At last!" as he stood, the wooden boards groaning under his weight.

The man hesitated, looking back at the safety of the porch as they entered the sun-shinning path that led into the woods. He realized that it was, "Just a dream," but he was still scared.

Although there were many sounds in the forest, such as birds chirping and leaves rustling, his senses were sharpened and he was aware of every change in the atmosphere. He proceeded farther, with Help trotting at his side and happily sniffing the ground. But like the quiet before a storm, he sensed the tension building with each step.

Then he stopped in a clearing, the dream coming back to him. Grasping Help's collar firmly, he whispered, "This is where it happened." Dark shadows danced across the forest floor as the sunlight flickered. He felt the cold wind breathing down his neck, and he felt a feeling of fear in his chest.

The man felt a wave of safety and protection as Help barked. He braced himself and said, "We'll face it together, whatever it was." He prepared to face whatever was in store for him, whether it was in the woods or in the back of his mind. He knew that something was still there, he could feel it. It is probably some version of what he saw in the woods. Each body, or animal, that the demon takes, it tends to make a much more exaggerated, form of it.

He couldn't help but wonder, though, as they continued their journey: was the darkness still waiting for an opportunity to reappear in their lives?